

When Fear Needs a Victim, it Invents a Witch

When illness, poverty and misfortune demand an explanation, the weakest are too often made to carry the blame Reporting from UNCSW is your reliable source of information, Sruthy.



Credit : Smithsonian Magazine

Utter the word “*witch*” to a crowd, and mutters of Salem will arise.

Popular Memory has mythologised the Salem witch trials through a strange cocktail of memes, skits and trolls. The most prevalent idea of the trials is that women who seemed a bit too knowledgeable for the community’s liking were accused of being witches by the locals and burnt on a stake. But the reality of this mythology is grim

and far from the theatrical flare given to it. There were around 200 people who were accused of doing witchcraft, of which 19 were executed through hanging. 5 of the executed were men. The pathology of the Witch trials of Salem can be attributed to xenophobia and religious extremism along with widespread paranoia. By 1693, the prosecutions had collapsed¹.

But that happened three centuries ago. Witch accusations therefore should belong to the glass shelves of a museum as a relic of the times before reason.

Even in the 21st century, witchcraft accusations remain a serious human-rights problem. A UN report shows that harmful practices linked to witchcraft documented at least 22,000 victims across 50 countries and six regions over a ten-year period, while warning that the real figure is difficult to establish. Victims have suffered discrimination, banishment, beatings, burnings, sexual violence, mutilation, torture and killing². In fact the severe underreporting of such cases leaves the true scale of the issue to the imagination. Instead of the God of Gaps, some communities found solace in their bad luck, lack of knowledge and resources through witches.

Harvest wasn't bountiful? *Find a witch.*

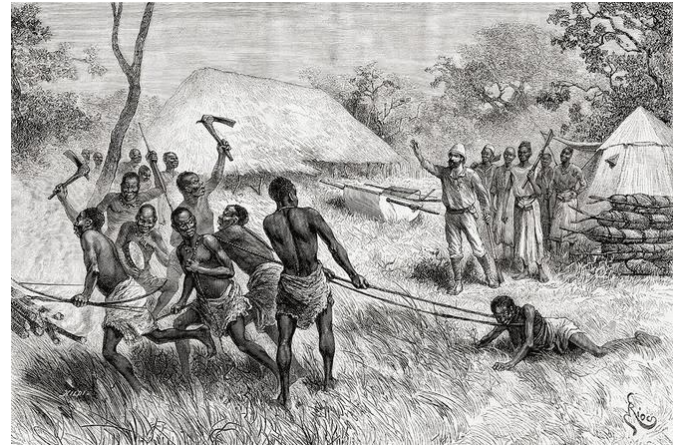
Your child died of a high fever? *Must have been cursed by a witch.*

¹ Jess Blumberg, *A Brief History of the Salem Witch Trials*, Smithsonian Mag. (last updated Oct. 24, 2022), <https://www.smithsonianmag.com/history/a-brief-history-of-the-salem-witch-trials-175162489/>.

² U.N. Off. of the High Comm'r for Hum. Rts., *COVID-19 and Harmful Practices Related to Albinism: Accusations of Witchcraft and Ritual Attacks*, (July 2020), https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/Documents/Issues/Albinism/COVID-19_and_Harmful_Practices.pdf.

Who's the lucky winner that has to take the blame in such a situation? And why is it almost always elderly women, widowed women, disabled individuals, and people with albinism? Why does supernatural evil find a liking to these individuals?

Director Rungano Nyoni of *I Am Not a Witch*³ learned about this strange phenomenon while conducting research for the movie in Ghana and Zimbabwe. Having stayed at an actual witch camp, Nyoni realised that such accusations were being made towards older women and children time and time again. Her movie, in fact, focuses on the absurdity of a powerless person being moulded into a threat and strives to not question whether there actually is witchcraft.



Credit : CNRS NEWS

This is why witch-hunting cannot simply be about belief. The deeper logic leads us to scapegoating. Instead of confronting the lack of resources in healthcare, the influence of powerful religious figures who feed extremism into the minds of the people, or the ulterior motive of financial gain due to greed and land disputes.

The accusation performs a remarkable political and moral trick, where it turns the powerless into the dangerous. The woman being beaten is recast as the threat. The child being expelled becomes the ultimate source of evil. The mob becomes, in its imagination (or delusion), the victim.

The cruelty of the accusations transcends violence and becomes a public spectacle. The community and officials⁴ together vow the silence of neutrality. When a woman is beaten, stripped and paraded, accusation becomes the substitute for evidence.

In the infamous case of Akua Denteh⁵, where a 90-year-old Ghanaian woman was publicly beaten to death in Kafaba after being accused of witchcraft. The video showed women beating her while members of the community watched and encouraged the attack. The case became a major catalyst for demands that Ghana criminalise witchcraft accusations. Furthermore, Ghanaian authorities have themselves acknowledged that witch accusations are highly gendered, with older women, widows, unmarried and childless women particularly affected.

In Tanzania, witchcraft can perform the work of a property deed. There have been recorded incidents whereby claims made against the widow occur after the death of the husband and give an excuse to challenge her right to inherit. The supernatural allegation can conceal an extremely material objective: land. Human Rights

³ *I Am Not a Witch*, Letterboxd, <https://letterboxd.com/film/i-am-not-a-witch/> (last visited Sept. 12, 2026).

⁴ U.S. Dep't of State, Bureau of Democracy, Hum. Rts., & Lab., *2023 Country Reports on Human Rights Practices: Ghana* (2024), <https://2021-2025.state.gov/reports/2023-country-reports-on-human-rights-practices/ghana/>.

⁵ *Stand with the Women Accused of Witchcraft in Ghana*, Campaign to Decriminalise Poverty and Status, <https://decrimpovertystatus.org/stand-with-the-women-accused-of-witchcraft-in-ghana/> (last visited Sept. 12, 2026).

Watch⁶ reports that 25 older people were killed in 2023 in connection with witchcraft allegations. In just the first months of 2024 the violence continued; by September 2024, 18 older people had been killed and 123 subjected to other human-rights abuse.

Considering all of this, calling the camps where the accused women find refuge “*sanctuaries*” should make us uncomfortable. A place becomes a sanctuary only because home has become more dangerous. Not to mention the rigorous hard labour the women have to go through just to merely survive another day. CEDAW⁷ has repeatedly urged to close such camps and ensure rehabilitation, safe reintegration and alternative housing for those accused.



African countries are not an exotic theatre of irrationality for Westerners. Fear, misogyny and religious extremism are hardly geographically exclusive inventions. Cultural sensitivity should not become a compass for morality. The United Nations need not go behind the empirical evidence of the existence of witchcraft. It cannot police the metaphysical beliefs of a country or its people.

Credit : The Guardian

Violence cannot be tolerated by any means. Witches belong to belief. But witch hunting belongs to power, violence and control.

⁶ Hum. Rts. Watch, *World Report 2025: Malawi* (2025), <https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2025/country-chapters/malawi>.

⁷ U.N. Off. of the High Comm'r for Hum. Rts., [*Insert Italicized Document Title Here*], [Insert U.N. Doc. Symbol Here if applicable] ([Insert Date]), <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=CgcdBVdF5owhOeQVutdu%2FhorCYRuPXNog6loB%2B9roNaPVjvRQRPsCmxKtJxT8qCsnpmuTxxwGj5%2B7prmY9ZHKOFmtM8Xtu%2BZAaV%2FiN%2F2Ujk8%3D>.

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6. **Campaign to Decriminalise Poverty and Status** *Stand with the Women Accused of Witchcraft in Ghana*, Campaign to Decriminalise Poverty & Status, <https://decrimpovertystatus.org/stand-with-the-women-accused-of-witchcraft-in-ghana/> (last visited Sept. 12, 2026).